

Divergent–Convergent Thinking

Generate broadly, then select and refine

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Creative work alternates between two modes: **divergent thinking**, which generates many varied options from a single starting point, and **convergent thinking**, which analyses, evaluates and narrows to the best. Keeping the two separate protects fragile early ideas from premature judgement.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

The divergent/convergent distinction stems from J.P. Guilford's (1950) structure-of-intellect research; it was popularised for design as the paired 'diamonds' of the Design Council's Double Diamond.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

People instinctively judge ideas as they produce them, which suppresses quantity and originality. Naming the two modes lets teams deliberately defer evaluation and expand the option space first.

HOW IT IS USED

A session is explicitly split: a divergent phase (quantity, no criticism, wild ideas welcome) followed by a convergent phase (grouping, prioritising, choosing against criteria). Facilitators signal the switch clearly.

WHEN IT IS USED

In every ideation and problem-framing activity, and as the structural logic behind brainstorming, HMW sprints and the Double Diamond.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Facilitators, design teams and anyone running a structured creative session.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

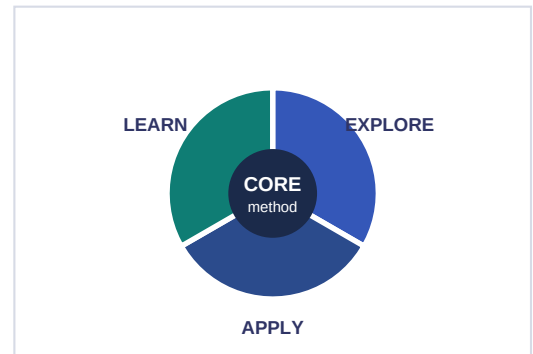


Figure 1. Divergent–Convergent Thinking framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It gives brainstorming its **discipline**: rather than a vague 'be creative', teams get an explicit rhythm that has become the backbone of design-thinking process models.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Brainstorming *Slibrary 7*

Dot Voting *Slibrary 2*

Double Diamond *Slibrary 3*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Guilford, J.P. (1950) 'Creativity', *American Psychologist*, 5(9), pp. 444–454.

Design Council (2005) *The Double Diamond*. London: Design Council.